

The Sūtra on Manifestly Attaining the Aim of Accomplishing the Great Uṣṇīṣa of the Blessed One, the Secret of the Tathāgata

Toh 236 · Derge Kangyur

བཅོམ་ལ་ལྷ་འདས་ཀྱི་ཉམས་ཏེ་ཆེ་པ་དེ་བཞུགས་གཤགས་པའི་གཞུང་བ་སྒྲུ་པའི་དེའོ་མངའོ་པར་ཐོ་

Toh 236 in the Kangyur is a sūtra known in English as "The Sūtra of the Courageous Conduct of All Bodhisattvas," concerned with manifestly attaining the aim of accomplishing the great uṣṇīṣa — the cranial protuberance — of the Blessed One, described as the secret of the Tathāgata. The text presents itself as the tenth chapter of a larger ten-thousand-verse sūtra, opening with the Tathāgata addressing his retinue, including Ānanda, from a lion throne, and belongs to the broader class of Mahāyāna sūtra literature focused on bodhisattva practice. The Tibetan title begins with a phrase indicating it concerns the accomplishment of the tathāgata's great uṣṇīṣa, and while precise Sanskrit and Tibetan short-form titles are not fully determinable from the available material, the text is clearly situated within the sūtra division of the Kangyur. It was translated into Tibetan by the monk Yeshe De, who also revised and finalized it in accordance with the royal editing decree standardizing Tibetan Buddhist translations.

Translated into Tibetan by the monk Yeshe De, who requested and revised it, and who, through the new royal editing decree, further corrected and finalized it.

In the Tibetan language: The Sūtra of the Courageous Conduct of All Bodhisattvas, which is the cause for manifestly attaining the aim of accomplishing the great uṣṇīṣa of the Blessed One, the secret of the Tathāgata — the tenth chapter from the ten-thousand-verse sūtra. First section.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Then, at that time, the Tathāgata's body, which was like a mountain of refined gold, rose back from the lion throne of the sacred Dharma seat, was supported by a precious image-support, and, leaning upon it, he spoke to the entire retinue, including Ānanda and the others:

"You — along with those in training (śaikṣa), those beyond training (aśaikṣa), and the pratyekabuddhas — should generate the mind of unsurpassed, great

awakening and take up the sublime feeling. I have already taught you the Dharma of correct accomplishment, yet you have still not thoroughly understood it. Within the yoga of calm abiding and insight, the works of māra, subtle upon subtle, and the realm of māra appear directly. If you cannot recognize these, the mind cannot be said to be properly purified, and you fall into false views. At certain intervals you are seized by the māra of the aggregates; at certain intervals, by the māra of the gods; at certain intervals, you are possessed and find opportunity given to hungry ghosts and asuras. Within, the mind does not feel it, and it is taken to be like a thief. Moreover, from within that, one who attains even just a small measure of realization thinks 'This is enough, I am accomplished' — that is exactly like attachment to the four meditative concentrations. That is the monk who has committed an act without interval, having deceived by thinking 'I have attained a noble realization.' Even at the point when a god's life runs out, such an omen appears outwardly, and one slanders an arhat by saying 'He will take on a subsequent body,' and thereby falls into the interminable hell. Listen, and reflect well, and take it to mind: I shall now explain this for your sake in precise and detailed distinction."

When this was declared, Ānanda rose from his seat, and those in the retinue who were suitable disciples rejoiced greatly, bowed with their heads to the ground, and, with body and mind exceedingly reverent and tender, listened once more from within the compassionate intention of the Blessed One.

Then the Blessed One declared to Ānanda and the entire retinue:

"You and the others should understand this. The supreme and clear feeling of essential nature, the expansive feeling of suchness — in relation to all the buddhas of the ten directions and the defiled world-beings born from the twelve classes of beings, these are not separately distinct, and they are not different, yet the confusion arising from the error in the object of mistaken perception that is not correct has generated and given rise to denseness and craving. Having thus been born and having arisen, for that reason emptiness comes to exist as having an inherent nature, and this is error in every direction. Because the continual stream of false appearance arising from error is uninterrupted, the world has come into being. Therefore, there is not a single atom-field in the ten directions that is without defilement. Such is the carriage of error — know this to be the construction of incorrect perception that is not genuine. The empty sky was born from within your own mind. For example, just as clouds suddenly arise from the sky and all worldly beings find

themselves within it, if any among you do not turn toward this correctness, then all the emptiness of the ten directions settles and clears — why would all objects of the space-element move, or greatly stir? The bodhisattvas and arhats of the ten directions who have exhausted defilements, practicing yoga in meditative concentration and samādhi —

when mind and field settle into luminous suchness in one-pointed meditative absorption, then all the palaces and dwelling-places of every king of māras, of gods, humans, asuras, and low-born sentient beings will tremble, and the great earth will shake violently. Those who dwell in the water, those who dwell on dry land, and those who fly through the sky — why should all of these, together with yourselves, be caused to tremble and quake? There are asuras, hungry ghosts, and heavenly māras who stir with great aversion, and they may come against you who are cultivating meditative concentration and do you harm. Yet when, within the midst of habituation to the stain of signs, you touch the very essence with feeling-sensation, then it is like a flame struck by wind, or like a sword thrust into water — one cannot harm the other. Against the firm dam of the adversary's assault, your inner warmth, like boiling hot water, so swiftly and readily dissolves it that whatever blessing the māras and others may project is exhausted as their own affliction and comes to nothing.

In such a way it resembles a guest — there is both establishment and also shattering and dispersal. When the lord of the five aggregates within your mind is confused, and a guest finds an opening, if you contemplate with full recognition of that very sensation, delusion will not arise, and the assault of māras will be unable to prevail over you. When you enter into the luminosity of the purified aggregates, all the hosts of error vanish separately and individually, and luminosity is able to dispel the darkness. If even when the harmful ones approach you remain self-subdued, how could they dare to harm one in meditative concentration? If you have not fully recognized this through sensation, then you are deceived by the aggregates. Dear Ānanda, you would thereby become a son of māra, performing the practices of māra's people. Even a witch of little power, through the power of mantra, can shatter your moral discipline. Yet although one single rule among the eighty-four thousand rules of conduct may be broken, because your mind is utterly pure, you will not be confused or bewildered, and since merit is present, your precious body will not go astray. It is like a great minister's house that, if divided moment by moment into separate portions and removed from you, renders him unable to take shelter. Dear Ānanda, know this well.

When you practice yoga at the heart of awakening, all that is clear, luminous, moving, and motionless will not disturb you. Abiding in the suchness that is straightforward and of one taste in expression, all signs are exhausted. Without obscuration, that is freedom from signs. When one rests in meditative absorption and samādhi, it is like a person with eyes who has entered into darkness: one's nature is clear and transparent, yet the light of mind has not yet arisen — that is the obscuration of the aggregate of form. But when one with eyes sees clearly in all ten directions with nothing whatsoever left out, that is called the exhaustion of the aggregate of form; that person has passed beyond the dregs of the age. To examine this matter is in order to train away the root of incorrect perception.

Dear Ānanda, abiding and training in such a way, one becomes clear and lucid. From the undisturbed four elements, for just an instant the mind appears as if the body offers no obstruction. This is called a momentary arising from cultivation in which the province of clarity and luminosity manifests — it is not that one has become a noble one. If one does not think "I have become noble," it may serve as an auspicious sign of virtue; but if one thinks "I have become noble," one falls into the realm of the erroneous.

Dear Ānanda, again, when that same mind is trained and pure, and from the inner clarity and luminosity of the body, in just a moment, there suddenly emerges from within that person's body the freedom from demons — yet the nature of the body remains exactly as it is: one sees that it has neither diminished nor deteriorated. This is called an arising from diligence that flows into the province of luminosity through the limbs of form.

This is not the fruit of becoming noble. If one does not think "I have become noble," it may serve as an auspicious sign of virtue; but if one thinks "I have become noble," one falls into the realm of the erroneous.

Dear Ānanda, again, when that same mind is trained and clear, at that time the mind, the mentation, and consciousness — without being altered by guests or hosts in the usual way — are gathered into oneness apart from the body that is held, and rest in meditative equipoise; and then, in just a moment, from empty space there suddenly arises from all ten directions a sound like the voice of one bearing the profound meaning of the Dharma. This is called the accomplishment of a virtuous cause arising from the stirring and rising of mind, mentation, and consciousness. It is an auspicious sign of virtue, not the fruit of the noble ones. If one thinks "I have become noble," one falls onto the

wrong path.

Dear Ānanda, again, from within that same mind, bright and clear, in just a moment a light leaps forth from the mind, and it pervades all ten directions taking on the color of Jambu-river gold; and every form and appearance transforms into the body of a Tathāgata, so that Vairocana the Tathāgata appears dwelling in a celestial palace of stacked divine light, surrounded by the retinues of ten buddhas, with a vision as of ten million buddha-fields and lotus flowers appearing together. This is called attachment through absorption and entry by mental consciousness. That illumination of the entire world arising from the light of the purified mind also ceases all at once. It is fitting as an auspicious sign of virtue, but it is not the fruit of the noble ones. If one grasps at it thinking "I have become noble," one falls into the realm of the lower path.

Again, from that same mind, refined and bright in clarity, when examination flows on unbroken, tamed and subdued and leaping forward — in just a moment, from the sky in all ten directions, the color of the seven precious substances appears, and in between it turns to an eight-hued radiance; and the pervasive fullness of blue, yellow, red, and white, each appearing unmixed and distinct — this arises from taming, subduing, and the leaping forward of the mind. It also ceases all at once. It has not become noble. If one does not think "I have become noble," it may serve as an auspicious sign of virtue; but if one grasps at it thinking "I have become noble," one falls into the realm of the wrong path.

Again, when that same mind has been trained for a long time and from its unstirred, clear purity — in just a moment the mind sees all manner of things in the pitch-dark of night, just as clearly as one sees in daytime. This vision is called an arising from the clarity of the most subtle subtlety of the refined mind. It is an auspicious sign of virtue, not the attainment of the noble. If one thinks "I have become noble," one falls into the realm of the erroneous.

Again, when that same mind has been cultivated and expanded into space — in just a moment the mind sees the four elements as like grass and wood: though burned by fire or cut by weapons, there is no sensation; though fire's light spreads, there is no scorching; and when flesh is cut it is like trimming a log. This is called arising from the aggregate of the gathering of subtle particles of the four elements having become thus. That too ceases in a single moment. It is fitting as an auspicious sign of virtue, but it is not the attainment

of the noble. If one grasps at it thinking "I have become noble," one falls into the realm of the erroneous.

Again, when that same mind has been accomplished in utter purity and abides at the far reach of the domain of diligence — in just a moment the mind sees the vast earth of all ten directions, with its mountains and rivers, and sees that it has itself become a buddha-field endowed with the seven precious substances, filled and pervaded with vessels brimming full; and tathāgatas and buddhas as numerous as the grains of sand in the Ganges River are seen dwelling in adorned, stacked, and towering palaces.

filling all the sky. And below, the hells of sentient beings are seen. Above, the celestial palaces of the gods are seen as though nothing could obstruct them. The name for this is: it arises from deep, long-standing attachment to a perception sunk in weariness and elation. It is not the arising of nobility. If one thinks "I have become noble," that is a wholesome sign, but if one grasps at it thinking "I have obtained the fruit of the noble ones," one falls into the realm of the erroneous.

Again, from that same mind having been trained in faith for a long time, in just a moment the mind, at the height of the midnight sky, sees at a great distance a marketplace, a city, and friends and companions. In between, the sound of what is called conversation is heard, and one sees what appears to be sitting outside of obstacles. The name for this is: it arises from the mind having been pressed down and expelled. It is a wholesome sign, but it is not the arising of nobility. If one thinks "I have become noble," one falls into the realm of the erroneous.

Again, from having trained the mind together with that state for a long time, one sees the bodies and appearances of genuine spiritual friends spontaneously transformed, appearing in various forms. The name for this is: it is a deceiving mind — an asura has entered within. In between, one has been deceived by a celestial māra which, having entered the interior of the mind, speaks fluently and without obstruction on the meaning of profound Dharma. This is not the arising of nobility. If one does not think "I have become noble," then the activity of the māra will be pacified and will cease. If one thinks "I have become noble," one falls into the realm of the erroneous.

O Nandā, these ten are the forewarning signs of meditative absorption. All of them belong to the aggregate of form. They arise in this way because of erring in practice, having been misled by the birth of a person with a material frame

whose own warmth has not yet been secured, and having encountered such a cause and condition, one goes astray without knowing it oneself. To think "I am noble" becomes a great falsehood and results in falling into the great hells. You and those like you should rely on this teaching. When the five hundred final years have passed since the Tathāgata's nirvāṇa — in that future time — proclaim these matters, teach them; and if a son of a god seizes upon a form so that māra finds no opening, and gives counsel with diligence, offering protection and refuge, the aim of the unsurpassed will be accomplished.

O Nandā, sons of good family, entering into meditative absorption and calm abiding, when the aggregate of form is exhausted, one sees the mind of all buddhas — just as forms appear in the inside of a pure mirror — and one gains the ability to engage with it. When error approaches the mind from outside it cannot cause wavering; just as a hungry ghost is weighed down, with its limbs and previous history intact, the seeing of buddhas and hearing of buddhas is without confusion. The name for this is: one has been obscured by the aggregate of feeling.

If from that state of being weighed down one recovers and the mind becomes free of the body, and one then inquires as one wishes, one gains independence in going and staying, and there is no obscuration. The name for this is: the aggregate of feeling is exhausted. That person has passed beyond the dregs of views. If one examines this matter, it is for the purpose of accumulating the root of a false perception.

O Nandā, sons of good family, remaining in that state, from profound inner darkness, a brightness arises inwardly in the mind. Having attained a great radiance, in just a moment of mind an inexhaustible compassion arises, and one looks with loving-kindness upon all beings as a mother fly looks upon her single offspring. Likewise, as compassionate mind arises, tears fall involuntarily. The name for this is: it arises from what is called the practice of sublimity. As regards this feeling, it contains no fault, yet it is not the arising of nobility. If one is not carried away by that feeling, one will not go astray; after a long while it will settle and cease.

If one thinks, "I am a noble one," one falls into the māra of compassion, and upon seeing people, compassion arises and tears flow without ceasing. One loses one's place in the authentic ranks and falls astray into error.

Furthermore, dear sons of good family, within that meditative absorption the aggregate of form appears pacified, and the aggregate of feeling is clear and

pure. From the direct appearance of the Victor's marks, a mind arises that is immovable for even a single moment of mind. Firm in courage and swift in resolve, one thinks that one's mind is equal to all buddhas, and one thinks that in just an instant one can traverse three immeasurable aeons. The name for this is: being slain by the distinction of excessive haste through the swiftness of qualities. As regards this feeling, it contains no fault, yet it is not the arising of nobility. If one is not carried away by that feeling, one will not go astray; after a long while it will settle and cease.

If one thinks, "I am a noble one," one falls into the māra of madness. Upon seeing people, arrogance and pride arise, and conceit beyond compare arises — one does not regard the buddha as one's teacher, one does not regard humans as one's inferiors. One loses one's place in the authentic ranks and falls astray into error. Within that meditative absorption, the aggregate of form appears pacified, and the aggregate of feeling is clear and pure; yet from this, the power of gnosis becomes attached and subtle. Turning back, one sees nothing at all — the fresh meaning of what was before is not seen. Afterwards the mind is lost, and from within the mind, for just a single moment of mind, one is tormented by the extreme thirst of diligence. Thinking at all times, without distraction, holding single-pointedly in mind, one thinks that mind has become the defining characteristic of diligence. The name for this is: distorted cultivation of wisdom, which is mere wandering. As regards this feeling, it contains no fault; yet it is not the arising of nobility.

If one thinks, "I am a noble one," one falls into the māra of mindfulness, and fixes the mind in single-pointed grasping, holding the mind constantly. One loses one's place in the authentic ranks and falls astray into error. Dear sons of good family, within that meditative absorption the aggregate of form appears pacified, and the aggregate of feeling is clear and pure; yet from this, the power of wisdom is suppressed by the meditative absorption and becomes dull. Through losing the sharp mind, one holds in mind the Victor's intrinsic nature from within the mind; then doubt arises concerning one's own mind, and one thinks, "I myself am Vairocana." Grasping at satisfaction with a small attainment — the name for this is: a cultivation that is perpetually consumed by distraction, lost and extinguished. Knowing and seeing have sunk into dullness. As regards this feeling, it contains no fault; yet it is not the arising of nobility.

If one thinks, "I am a noble one," one falls into the māra-mind of base and inferior insatiability. Upon seeing people, one declares that one has oneself

attained the unsurpassed ultimate reality, and one loses one's place in the authentic ranks and falls astray into error. Dear sons of good family, within that meditative absorption the aggregate of form appears pacified, and the aggregate of feeling is clear and pure; yet from this, no fresh meaning is attained, and the old mind is lost. Being neither the one nor the other, a timid mind arises that is pleasing to oneself, and in just an instant, immeasurable sorrows arise that afflict all the arising and ceasing of the mind — it is like sitting on a throne of hot iron, and one feels, as though having drunk poison, an unwanted sensation. One constantly tells others, "Cut off your life and take up liberation!" The name for this is: the loss of the means of conduct. As regards this feeling, it contains no fault; yet it is not the arising of nobility.

If one thinks, "I am a noble one," one falls into the māra-mind of grief of the same kind. One takes delight in holding a weapon in hand, cutting one's own flesh, and bringing about one's own death.

In the intermediate periods, grief constantly arises and one flees, going to mountains and valleys, taking no pleasure in seeing other people. One falls away from the rank of the true and tumbles into errant deviation.

Again, O sons of good family, within that meditative absorption, the form aggregate is at peace; the feeling aggregate is clear and pure. Out of that state of purity, in a single moment of mind, an immeasurably intense joy arises in one, beyond one's own control. The name for this is: one is bound by the bliss of an unruly nature of wisdom. As regards this feeling, it contains no fault; yet it is not the arising of nobility.

If one thinks, "I am a noble one," one enters into the māra-mind of the same kind that delights in constant craving, and having entered deeply within it, whenever one sees people one laughs, and in the village one sings and dances, thinking, "I have attained a liberation that is freed of all obscurations within myself." One falls away from the rank of the true and tumbles into errant deviation.

Again, O sons of good family, within the meditative absorption, the form aggregate is at peace; from what appears and is luminous within the feeling aggregate, thinking "I am satisfied," a great pride stirs in a single moment of mind, without foundation. Accordingly, pride in "I," the pride of thinking oneself great, the pride of "mine," the pride of saying "I," the pride of saying "it is I," the pride of saying "a little," and wrong pride — all arise simultaneously. In the depths of the mind, even when one compares one's own teachers and

the Tathāgatas of the ten directions, one considers oneself superior to them; and as for the śrāvakas below that, and their pratyekabuddhas, what need is there even to speak of them? The name for this is: one who has obtained victory over oneself, yet is without refuge of any kind through an unruly wisdom. As regards this feeling, it contains no fault; yet it is not the arising of nobility.

If one thinks, "I am a noble one," one enters into the māra-mind of great pride, and one no longer pays homage at stūpas and temples, one tears apart sacred images and the Dharma, and one speaks to one's patrons as follows: "For some, it is gold; for others, a drum, earth, wood, bark, or leaves. For others still, it is cloth and flowers." One fails to show reverence, and one teaches perversely, claiming that the body of flesh is truly permanent, urging reliance on earth and wood as objects of faith in an inverted manner, declaring: "Have faith and trust in me, cut yourselves loose and come freely; bury it under the earth." By inducing doubt and disparagement in sentient beings, one falls into the hell of boundless wrongdoing, falls away from the rank of the true, and tumbles into errant deviation.

Again, O sons of good family, within that meditative absorption, the form aggregate is at peace; the feeling aggregate is clear and pure. Within that clarity and luminosity, a great inclination following in the wake of awareness arises — one whose purpose is vast and pure, active in this domain. In a single moment of mind, an immeasurably serene and blissful mind arises, and one attains great independence within oneself, thinking, "I am a noble one." The name for this is: the attainment of all the causes of wisdom and lightness of field. As regards this feeling, it contains no fault; yet it is not the arising of nobility.

If one thinks, "I am a noble one," one enters deeply into the māra-mind of the same kind that mingles with lightness of field, thinking "I am accomplished and complete," and one strives no further at what remains to be accomplished. One disparages monks who have not heard much, and through doubt and laziness, one later falls into the hell of boundless wrongdoing, falls away from the rank of the true, and tumbles into errant deviation.

Again, O sons of good family, within the meditative absorption, the form aggregate is at peace and clear; the feeling aggregate is clear and pure. Within that clear feeling, one attains the intrinsic nature of emptiness.

Within that state, the mind enters for just a moment into the peaceful cessation, and one then enters a one-sided emptiness, thinking, "Dependent origination does not arise." As long as emptiness appears directly to one's mind, one thinks, "I continuously know arising and cessation," and upon experiencing that, there is no fault. But one has not thereby become a noble one. If one thinks, "I have become a noble one," then the māra-mind of emptiness enters within, and one denigrates the observance of moral discipline. This is called the lesser vehicle. Such a person says to a patron who has long trusted him, "For a bodhisattva there is no guarding and no breaking — so drink alcohol, eat meat. Spread licentiousness far and wide." Through the power of māra, people are gathered in. Yet those people do not themselves hold doubt or denigration — their minds sink deeply into the realm of the hungry ghosts. Even in between, eating excrement and drinking urine is counted the same as eating meat and drinking alcohol. Saying "All of that is equally one in emptiness," they smash the discipline and Vinaya of the buddhas. Even those of uncertain resolve are drawn into wrongdoing, and thus they fall away from the rank of the true and tumble into errant deviation.

O sons of good family, within the meditative absorption, the form aggregate is at peace; the feeling aggregate, being clear and pure, passes beyond clarity and appears as emptiness. Through deep attachment within that gathered mind of apparent emptiness, for a brief moment a mind of measureless existence arises, and going to the very limit of existence, one is seized by a kind of madness and proceeds to engage in licentiousness oneself. This is called being attached within the mind to the sign of blissful progress in meditative absorption. Lacking wisdom, one has no refuge in oneself, and one leads others likewise into licentiousness. Upon experiencing that, there is no fault, but one has not become a noble one. If one thinks, "I have at least become a noble one," then the māra-mind of attachment enters within, and one teaches that the path of attachment is the path of awakening. One teaches: "Engage in licentiousness just as a householder does — such conduct is the upholding of the Dharma's offspring." Through the power of the asuras, in the later time, one so teaches crowds of foolish lowly ones numbering a hundred, two hundred, three hundred, four hundred, five hundred, six hundred, or up to many thousands. Then that person's māra becomes weary and reaches the limit of its satisfaction; their body falls away and they lose their splendor, and they are caught in the king's legal proceedings. Sentient beings are made to doubt, and they are caused to fall into the hell of

boundless wrongdoing.

These ten are the ominous signs of meditative absorption. All of them belong to the feeling aggregate. They arise thus from errant meditation. After having incited persons of manly courage to practice, one has not oneself maintained the warmth of experience; meeting with such causes and conditions, one does not recognize one's own confusion; and thinking, "I am a noble one," this becomes a great lie, and one falls into the hell of boundless wrongdoing.

This is the Tathāgata's particular instruction laid down for all of you and all sentient beings alike, since I shall pass away. Know it well. Holding it as a dhāraṇī so that the god Māra finds no opportunity, and guarding it as counsel, the unsurpassable path is accomplished.

O beloved sons of good family, rejoice: when the feeling aggregate is exhausted through the cultivation of meditative absorption — even though the defilements are not yet exhausted — the moment the mind separates from the body, it is like drawing an arrow shaft from a mold. When such attainment is reached, from the body of a lowly one, through the noble rank of the guru's awakening, one obtains a mental body all the way up to the sixty ranks of the noble ones.

There is no obstruction in going and coming. Consider the example of a person who, without waking from sleep, speaks coherently while dreaming, yet does not understand the meaning of what is being said. Those who are not asleep, however, understand every word. This is called being obscured by the aggregate of perception. When the signs of agitation are exhausted, all conceptual elaboration is calmed and purified, and one feels and is luminously clear — this is like wiping away the stain of the mind's defilements. When one surveys the entirety of births and deaths throughout a single round of saṃsāra from beginning to end, this is called the exhaustion of the aggregate of perception, and it is the passing beyond the dregs of affliction. This is because it is the root of the illusory perception of peace, in which inquiry into the meaning proceeds without obstruction.

O beloved sons of good family, when one is heedful and attentive on the profound path of turning back, emptied of the feeling aggregate, a bright and expansive meditative absorption arises; and from that arising of the clear, expansive meditative absorption, the mind becomes attached to it and craves it, and the mind desires and seeks to dwell in that wholesome state. At that moment the god Māra finds an opportunity: a sky-dwelling deity enters into

that person by means of supernatural power, and with speech recites sūtras and explains the Dharma. The person does not perceive this, and — deceived by Māra — thinks, "I myself have attained unsurpassable nirvāṇa." The son of good family, having come forward in his desire to gain recognition, relaxes his guard and teaches the Dharma; and for brief moments he manifests in the body of a monk so that other people see it. At other moments he manifests as Śakra (Indra), at other moments as a woman, at other moments as a fully ordained nun; at other moments he lies in a dark room and emits light from his body; at other moments he manifests as a bodhisattva, and when bewildered and confused people see this, they place their trust in him. That person then lets the mind wander away, breaks the Buddha's precepts of ethical discipline, secretly engages in licentiousness, speaks words of ill omen — and in just the same way the householders' livestock and property disappear one by one. At times he prophesies that the Tathāgata has gone to such-and-such a buddha-field; at times he teaches that a kalpa of fire is coming; at times that a kalpa of weapons is coming, and he fills people with fear and dread. That deluded, miserable hungry ghost has grown old and become a māra. Thereafter, disenchantment arises with respect to that person, and a mind of contentment is born; but when he separates from the body, he becomes entangled in a royal lawsuit, together with his preceptor and students. You must become aware of this before entering into saṃsāra. If you do not know that you have been confused and deceived, you will fall into the hell of uninterrupted torment.

O beloved sons of good family, when one is heedful and attentive but without clinging on the profound path of turning back, emptied of the feeling aggregate, a bright meditative absorption arises; and then, without accomplishing anything within that meditative absorption, the mind is let loose in distraction, floating and wandering, and attachment arises. At that moment the god Māra finds an opportunity: a sky-dwelling deity enters that person through supernatural power, and with speech recites sūtras and explains the Dharma. The person does not perceive this, and — deceived by Māra — thinks, "I have attained unsurpassable nirvāṇa." O sons of good family, coming forward in the direction of the desire for renown, he relaxes his guard and teaches the Dharma; and although his own body has not undergone any transformation, those who listen to his Dharma see him as seated upon a precious lotus. Those individual listeners also see, though they had never seen it before, that every part of his body has turned the color of gold. Yet those

people are bewildered and confused. At times he transforms into the form of a bodhisattva. With a mind at ease in its licentiousness, he breaks the Buddha's precepts of ethical discipline.

He engages in secret licentiousness, while with his words he says things such as these: "All buddhas have come into the world. In such-and-such a place there is a person who is a buddha, an emanation body who has come here. The people of such-and-such a place are bodhisattvas, emanations who have come into the world." Without any scruple or shame he thus teaches falsely, and people come to experience both longing and anguish. On account of this, the fruit of gnosis is blocked and diminishes. This person's name is the old hungry ghost who creates hallucinations, who has become a māra and does harm to that person. Then, in that person, there arises a mind of weariness and discontent; he is separated from that person's body, and together with his preceptor and disciples he falls into the legal proceedings of the king. You should perceive in advance before entering into cyclic existence. If you do not know that you are deceived and led astray, you will fall into the avīci hell without interval.

O sons of good family, when one is vigilant, not being caught by the stumbling block of erroneous shame regarding the aggregate of feeling as empty and profound, there arises from that a clear and expansive meditative absorption. Yet with perception that drifts under the swell of craving-mind, one engages in longing and seeking through attachment. At that moment, the heavenly māra finds an opportunity; a sky-dwelling deity enters into that person through supernatural power, and with words recites sūtras and expounds the Dharma, while that person does not realize it, and thinking himself deceived by the māra, thinks: "I myself have attained the unsurpassed, perfect nirvāṇa."

O sons of good family, coming in pursuit of the profit of knowledge, longing and seeking, he sits settled and teaches the Dharma. Even the people who listen to his Dharma in his physical presence, and those who listen to the Dharma from outside in his absence, know by themselves beforehand, before having heard the Dharma, what is being said. This is called mind. In a moment the mind changes: at times he recalls past and future lives; at times he is said to see the minds of others; at times he sees the hell realms; at times he knows the virtues and faults of the human realm; at times he speaks in verse; at times he talks to himself in a soliloquy; and at times, overcome by great joy, he says, "I have obtained what has never been attained before." At times he transforms into the form of a bodhisattva. Foolish and deluded, with craving

and attachment arising in his mind, he breaks the Buddha's precepts of ethical discipline, engages in secret licentiousness, and with his words proclaims: "There is a great buddha. There is a small buddha. There is an earlier buddha. There is a later buddha. Among them there are true buddhas and illusory buddhas, born buddhas and female buddhas." He speaks likewise about bodhisattvas. When people see this, their former minds are transformed and displaced, and they fall into wrong views.

This person's name is the old hungry ghost who knows how to transform minds, who has become a māra and does harm to that person. Then in that person there arises a mind of weariness and discontent; he is separated from his body, and together with his preceptor and disciples he falls into the legal proceedings of the king. You should perceive in advance before entering into cyclic existence. If you do not know that you are deceived and led astray, you will fall into the avīci hell without interval.

O sons of good family, when once again one is vigilant, not being caught by the stumbling block of erroneous shame regarding the aggregate of feeling as empty and at ease, there arises from that a clear and expansive meditative absorption. Yet craving arises toward the vital essence of other sentient beings in future lives, and from the very beginning to the very end there arises an attachment to feeling, a desire that distinguishes the particular qualities of a sharp and subtle mind. At that moment, when the heavenly māra finds an opportunity, a sky-dwelling deity enters into that person through supernatural power, and with words recites sūtras and expounds the Dharma, while that person does not realize it.

Deceived by the māra, that person thinks, "I have attained unsurpassed nirvāṇa." Then, sons of good family, he comes forward seeking to make distinctions, settles into an air of self-assurance, and expounds the Dharma. His body becomes radiant and imposing. Those who come with faith become calm and tamed, and those among them still in saṃsāra, upon hearing the Dharma, do become calm and tamed. Those very people think: "This one is a buddha," or "This is nirvāṇa," or "This is awakening," or "This is the Dharma." He says: "This body of flesh of mine, born one from another, grandfather to grandchild, is the body of the aggregation of Dharma. Its unbroken continuity — all of this itself — is the buddha-element. Apart from this there is no buddha-field, no color like gold." When people take this to be credible, they lose and forget their former mind, and clinging to that living body they declare: "We have attained what has never been attained." And so on — those

who are foolish and confused think at intervals, "This is awakening," then lose and forget their own minds, break the moral discipline and vows of the buddhas, practice debauchery in secret, and with their mouths speak words of craving, declaring: "The eye, the ear, the nose, and the tongue are all buddha-fields. The male organ and the female organ are the path of awakening. True nirvāṇa is something even the body cannot know." Such unseemly words are spoken, and people give rise to faith in them. The name for this māra is: the hungry ghost with venomous snake-poison, grown old and become a māra.

Then weariness and a sense of satisfaction arise in that person, and after he departs from that person's body, both the preceptor and the disciples become subject to a royal lawsuit. You must perceive this before being drawn into saṃsāra. If you do not know that you have been confused and deceived, you will fall into the avīci hell.

Sons of good family, again: remaining vigilant so as not to fall into the wrong shame that takes the aggregate of feeling to be empty and profound, from the clear and expansive meditative absorption that arises, one moves through the arising of spontaneous omens that pervade widely. From the outset, the mind craves and desires to perceive sudden and manifest signs. At that moment, when the heavenly māra finds an opportunity, a sky-dwelling deity enters into that person through supernatural power, and with words recites sūtras and expounds the profound Dharma, while that person does not realize it.

Deceived by the māra, he thinks: "I have attained unsurpassed nirvāṇa." Sons of good family, he comes to the place of those seeking sudden manifest signs, settles into an air of self-assurance, expounds the Dharma, and the listeners, in just a single moment of the mind, feel their bodies stabilized — as though they have become intimate companions for a hundred or a thousand years — and they become attached, find it impossible to part, and cannot bear to let go. They treat their bodies as equal to servants and slaves, make offerings through the four means of livelihood, yet feel no mental weariness or tedium. Each one also thinks of that person as their own former preceptor and virtuous spiritual friend. Furthermore, a mind of craving for the Dharma also arises, and the attachment to it is like lacquer and glue: declaring "We have attained what has never been attained," those foolish and confused people, relying on and drawing close to that mind, also break the moral discipline and vows of the buddhas, practice debauchery in secret, and with their mouths speak these words: "In a former life I was born as such-and-such a one. I liberated the

sentient beings of such-and-such a one. At that time my wives great and small, and my brothers and sisters, accompanied you and came here. In such-and-such a realm I made offerings to the buddha of such-and-such a one, and yet in the great realm of light a buddha resides — that place is the abode of all Tathāgatas." When they speak thus, people do not perceive what is happening, believe the deception, and lose their former minds.

It is an aged hungry ghost that has become a māra, and it harms that person. Then weariness and a sense of sufficiency arise in that person, and departing from that person's body, it — together with the preceptor and disciples — becomes entangled in the king's legal affairs. "Do not enter into saṃsāra; instead, feel this beforehand. If you do not know that you have been confused and deceived, you will fall into the Avīci hell." Sons of good family, one who is heedful and does not fall into the wrong extreme of distorting the profound emptiness of the aggregate of feeling, and in whom a clear and expansive meditative absorption arises, comes to crave entry into the deep mind, craves still greater effort and the calming of the aggregates, and a seeking mind is born that harms clarity. At that moment the māra of the gods finds an opening, and by the magic of a sky-deity enters that person, and speaks sūtras and teaches the Dharma with his mouth. That person does not perceive what is happening, and, being deceived by the māra, thinks to himself, "I have attained unsurpassable nirvāṇa." Sons of good family, when one comes in a state of seeking clarity, one settles into confidence and teaches the Dharma, and the people who listen to the Dharma also go off one by one, each striving with diligence. He says to one person in that assembly, "Without dying, you have obtained a rebirth in the animal realm." He then instructs another person, "Go and mount that one's wife," and that person is then unable to rise. All those in his retinue give rise to a mind of reverence and become self-tamed and peaceful. They are even able to look into the minds of those people. He breaks the moral discipline of the buddhas, manufactures ascetic practices, slanders monks, speaks ill of the Saṅgha, seeks fault in people, is heedless of shame, and speaks with his mouth of good and bad omens, not even going astray by so much as a hair's breadth of the timing — everything occurs just as he says. This is an aged hungry ghost of great power that has become a māra, and it harms that person. Then weariness and a sense of sufficiency arise in that person, and departing from that person's body, it — together with the preceptor and disciples — becomes entangled in the king's legal affairs. "Do not enter into saṃsāra; instead, feel this beforehand. If you do not know

that you have been confused and deceived, you will fall into the Avīci hell." Again, sons of good family, one who is heedful and does not fall into the wrong extreme of distorting the profound emptiness of the aggregate of feeling, and in whom a clear and expansive meditative absorption arises, comes to crave unseen and unheard things, and craves and seeks ascetic practices and past and future recollection. At that moment the māra of the gods finds an opening, and by the magic of a sky-deity enters that person, and speaks sūtras and teaches the Dharma with his mouth. That person does not perceive what is happening, and, being deceived by the māra, thinks to himself, "I have attained unsurpassable nirvāṇa." Sons of good family, when one comes in a state of craving past and future recollection, one settles into confidence and teaches the Dharma. During the very moments when that person teaches the Dharma, the māra acts in the intervals. Manifesting in the form of an animal, it takes up precious jewels — it takes hold of jewels and also takes up various other jewels in the same way. In the intervals it changes its body and also gives various jewels to people, and then enters back inside him. In the intervals it leads people underground, shows them precious jewels, and a vision of jewels blazing with moonlight appears, and those listening to the Dharma say, "We have obtained what we have never experienced before." He consumes large quantities of medicines and various grasses and herbs but does not eat good food. In the intervals, even though he eats only a single barleycorn or a single bean of healing medicine, by the power of the māra his body turns a ruddy color. He slanders monks.

He slanders the Saṅgha, yet others do not suspect that he deserves to be examined. He also displays and speaks of the sources of precious jewels in other lands and regions, and of noble ones (āryas) of the ten directions whose bodies are hidden. In the intervals, even the companions who travel with him see people of great wonder. Their names are: the hungry ghosts of mountain forests, of the earth, of villages, of citadels, and of prisons, who have grown old and become māras. In the intervals he engages in licentious conduct, violates the moral discipline and Vinaya of the Buddha, and leads people into licentious behavior. He applies diligence, eats grass and wood, and performs unceasing activities. He causes harm to that person. That person then becomes weary and develops a sense of contentment, separates from his body, and together with his abbot and disciples becomes entangled in the king's punishment. Therefore, recognize in advance, before you have entered into saṃsāra. If you do not know that you are deceived and deluded, you will

fall into the avīci hell.

Furthermore, noble sons, be vigilant, without becoming entangled in the perverse snare of holding the aggregate of feeling to be empty and profound, for from a clear and expansive meditative absorption there arises a craving to perform various miraculous powers, and one desires that through long training one will obtain might and strength. At that time the heavenly māra finds his opportunity, and a sky-deity enters that person through magical flight. That person does not perceive it, and deceived by the māra he thinks, "I have attained the unsurpassed nirvāṇa." He comes before noble sons who desire emanation, asserts himself boldly, teaches the Dharma, and has people place a lamp-vessel in that person's hand. The light from that lamp is directed onto the heads of the four assemblies who are listening to the Dharma. Multi-colored lights blaze above the heads of those listening to the Dharma, yet they have no nature of heat, and there is no burning. In the intervals he walks on water as though walking on land. In the intervals he sits motionless in the sky. In the intervals he also sits inside balls and inside skulls. In the intervals he passes through walls without obstruction and gains mastery over weapons and armies. He declares, "I myself am a buddha," dresses the body in grey robes, and has monks prostrate to him. He disparages meditative concentration and moral discipline, slanders the Saṅgha, seeks fault in people yet others do not suspect that he deserves to be examined, and in his speech he proclaims talk of miraculous powers. In the intervals he shows people visions of buddha-fields, but these are blessed by hungry ghosts and are not genuinely blissful. He praises licentious conduct, has no shame before great and censurable misdeeds, and says of unchaste behavior, "This is the teaching of the Dharma." Their names are: the mighty gods of sky and earth, the gods of mountains, the gods of lakes, the gods of wind, the gods of rivers, the gods of earth and stone, the gods of all grasses, herbs, and trees, the gods of accumulated aeons, the gods who transform minds, the mind-transforming nāga-dragons, long-lived sages (ṛṣis) whose life-span is exhausted and who have become hungry ghosts, sages whose life-span is exhausted and who are on the verge of death counted by years and whose bodies have not yet been abandoned, and hungry ghosts of ill omen that enter from within — these, having grown old, have become māras and cause harm to that person. From this he becomes weary and develops a sense of contentment, separates from his body, and together with his abbot and disciples becomes entangled in the king's case. Therefore, recognize in advance, before you have entered into

samsāra. If you do not know that you are deceived and deluded, you will fall into the avīci hell.

Furthermore, noble sons, be vigilant, without becoming entangled in the perverse snare of holding the aggregate of feeling to be empty and profound, for from a clear and expansive meditative absorption there arises a craving and seeking to engage in perverse conduct.

He trains for a long time and enters into the nature of the empty and profound, craving and seeking after it. At that point, a heavenly māra finds an opening, and a sky-dwelling god enters into that person through its supernatural powers, and through that god's speech, sūtras are recited and Dharma is taught, yet that person does not perceive it, and while being deceived by the māra, thinks to himself, "I have attained nirvāṇa."

Noble sons, having gone so far as to reach the cessation of craving, he settles into certainty and teaches the Dharma. In the midst of a great retinue, his body and mind become empty for just an instant, and he causes the retinue not to see him. Again, emerging from within that emptiness in just an instant of mind, he gains mastery over arising and ceasing. At times he displays his body as though made of beryl. At times he stretches out his hand downward and releases the fragrance of sandalwood. At times the ground outside, whether large or small, appears densely packed like fine dust. He also denigrates moral discipline and the Vinaya, looks down upon those who have gone forth in renunciation, and holds them in contempt. In his speech he constantly declares, "There is no cause and no effect. Once one dies, there is nothing lasting; there is no future existence, no noble one, and no body of a sentient being." Though he has not attained emptiness and purity, in secret he engages in unchaste conduct and licentious behavior. Again, claiming to have attained a mind of emptiness, he declares, "There is no dependent origination."

The name of this being is Rāhu, the asura (demigod) who eclipses the sun and moon, together with gold, crystal, auspicious grass, the gilīng bird, a frog, and other such beings — a long-lived asura who has accumulated a debt of ten thousand years of other lifetimes. It is born in that region, and having aged, it becomes a māra and causes harm to that person. Then that person grows weary of it and develops a sense of contentment; he separates from his body and, together with his abbot and disciples, becomes entangled in the king's case. Recognize this in advance, before you have entered into samsāra. If you

do not know that you are deceived and deluded, you will fall into the avīci hell.

Noble sons, be vigilant, without becoming entangled in the perverse snare of holding the aggregate of feeling to be empty and profound. For from a clear and expansive meditative absorption there arises in the mind a craving to live long; one craves and seeks after a long life. Casting aside the limbs of the aggregates, one hopes to gain sovereignty over one's life all at once and to obtain a body, wishing that subtle form might become permanent.

At that point, when a heavenly māra finds an opening, a sky-dwelling god enters into that person through supernatural powers, and through that god's speech, sūtras are recited and Dharma is taught. That person does not perceive that he has been deceived by the māra and thinks, "I have attained unsurpassed nirvāṇa."

Noble son, having gone so far as to reach the wish to live long, he settles into certainty, teaches the Dharma, and declares: "I will travel to other realms without obstruction." At times he travels as far as ten thousand leagues and returns in a single breath. He goes to other realms and brings back wealth, carrying it with him as he returns. At times, for those sitting together in a single house, he moves swiftly from the east wall to the west wall in just a few steps — yet even after many years he has not actually gone anywhere. Thereby he causes sentient beings to believe in him, and having believed, they think, "This one himself is a buddha." In his speech he declares: "All sentient beings of the ten directions are my children. All buddhas were born from me. They arose in my world. I am a buddha from the very beginning; though I appear in the world, I was not born from conditioned things." The name of this being is the heavenly māra who is lord of the world, and he even causes his own relatives and companions to act as his servants.

She is like a female hungry ghost of the darkness, like the kings of the four directions, like the child of a flesh-eater — she drinks the semen of men who have aroused the awakening mind yet lack meditative absorption. From time to time, seeing those who practice virtue without a teacher to guide them, she says, "I am the vajra-holder; I will grant you long life." Sometimes she manifests as a beautiful woman and, having engaged extensively in seduction, within not many years causes the kidneys and liver to wither. She also speaks to herself alone. When she encounters people and converses with them, she makes them become dull-witted, twists their minds, and does them harm. Without their noticing, they become entangled in the king's judicial

proceedings. When the time of death comes, before its moment arrives they wither and die. They also die suddenly. Recognize this before you have entered into saṃsāra. If you do not know that you are being deceived and led astray, you will fall into the hell of uninterrupted torment (avīci).

Ānanda, those ten māras will in the time yet to come emerge from my collected scriptures and enter into the minds of people who obstruct the path of Dharma. Sometimes, revealing themselves openly, they say to people: "I perceive and know complete, all-pervading awareness." They praise the practice of seduction and destroy the discipline of the buddhas. First deceived by the teacher, then deceived by the students, they urge each other on, one saying to another, "Practice seduction." In this way the asuras (demigods) twist the mind and enter into its very depths, and for nine lives at the nearest, or up to a hundred lives at the farthest, such people engage in virtuous conduct while becoming friends and companions of māra. Then, after those lives pass, they become servants of māra. After that they lose their place among those who possess complete and distinct knowing, and fall into the hell of uninterrupted torment.

Even if you have attained the exhaustion of defilements, do not enter into the peaceful cessation without having first set your aspiration prayer. In the evil final age of the future, arouse great compassion, and liberate and free the sentient beings who have genuine faith. Knowing and attaining this in a way that māra cannot obstruct — I have freed and liberated you from birth and death. Now you must all honor the words of the buddhas, for that is repaying the buddhas.

Ānanda, those ten are the forewarnings of meditative absorption, and all of them belong to the aggregate of formations. They arise in this way because meditation has gone astray. Having corrupted those people of weak constitution, they fail to sustain the warmth of their own experience; encountering such causes and conditions, they are led astray without knowing it themselves. The thought "I am a noble one" becomes a great lie, and they fall into the hell of uninterrupted torment.

You and the others, after I have passed into nirvāṇa — in the time that comes after — spread the instructions of the Tathāgata to all sentient beings without exception, and teach the meaning of this. Take heed. Hold it as a dhāraṇī so that the māra of the heavenly realms finds no opportunity. If you follow these instructions and guard them, the unsurpassable path will be accomplished.

This is the second and final section.

Ānanda, the person who, through settling in meditative absorption, has exhausted the aggregate of perception — for that person, the perceptions of dream are continuously suppressed and stilled. Waking and sleeping are always the same to them. Their feelings, being luminous, are empty and clear. It is as though the sky were unobscured, with no great dense clouds covering it. Looking out across the entire world, one sees the great earth, the great waters, and

People appear to be gathered inside a mirror, yet when reflections arise, there is no staining, and when they fade, there is no change. When one examines that which appears to be the receptacle of emptiness, it is recognized as the essential nature of the root of birth and death — namely, the habitual tendencies of former times — and when sought, it cannot be found. From the very beginning, it is of one taste with suchness.

All beings born from the twelve kinds in all ten directions may not comprehend this meaning, yet if they cultivate it for a long time, each will come to realize it inwardly. It is like taming a horse with a halter. This is called "obscured by the aggregate of formations."

In this way, the turbidity that has arisen from clarity is cleared away, and one enters into the very nature of clarity itself. When this is unified, there are no habitual tendencies. It is like muddy water that, once settled and cleared, is called clear. This is called "the aggregate of formations exhausted," and for that person, the defilements of sentient beings have been transcended. When this meaning is examined, it is profound and not easily seen. Ānanda, you should know this.

Fully realizing and seeing what is true: for sons of good family who enter meditative absorption, if they rest in that very true nature which has no object to apprehend, the māras of the gods will be of settled mind. Having purified and attained clarity, they know the root of their own lineage. If they then examine what is profound and clear within that lineage, understanding arises from a broad traversal of the ground and causes of the confusion of afflictions, and that person falls into one of two errors, both lacking a [true] cause.

The first is this: that person sees the cause at the foundational ground itself. Why is this? Because if one attains the destruction of the root of sentient beings, one acquires the merit of eight hundred eyes of the foundational ground. Cycling through however many sentient beings exist within eighty

thousand kalpas, dying here and being reborn beyond, one sees sentient beings cycling in that very saṃsāra. Since the eighty thousand kalpas prior to that are invisible and there is nothing to observe, one thinks to oneself, "I know that this is how it is," and reasons that sentient beings in this world and throughout all ten directions have existed of themselves by their very nature from eighty thousand kalpas onward without a cause. On account of this view, that person loses their place in the ranks of true and sublime practitioners and falls into the tīrthika view, thereby losing the essential nature of awakening.

The second is this: that person looks to the uncaused in the future. Why is this? Because that person sees the root of birth and death, and understands that humans are reborn as humans, birds as birds. They see that ravens are entirely black — that this arose from being washed away — and that white is that which has been washed clean. Gods and humans are entirely upright, animals entirely hunched. White came about through washing; black came about through alteration. And for eighty thousand kalpas there is no change. Up to the present moment, and for as long as the present moment endures, it is so. "I myself, being present, see awakening" — why? "Because awakening is achievable — know this!" And thinking, "The wealth and possessions that exist today exist without a cause" — reasoning thus, that person loses the all-pervading knowledge of the true and falls into the tīrthika view, losing the essential nature of awakening. This is called "the first tīrthika of the uncaused."

Again, Ānanda, if sons of good family rest in equanimity in the true nature that has no object in meditative absorption, the māras are of settled mind. They know the root of their own cycle, and if they examine what is profound and blissful within it, measuring sentient beings from within a proliferation of permanence, that person falls into one of four views of pervading permanence.

The first of these: one thinks to oneself that both mind and the objects of mind move of themselves without a cause from within, yet become known when active. For the birth-and-death cycles of however many sentient beings exist in all ten directions across twenty thousand kalpas, dying and being reborn, separating and scattering, none of this having ever been lost — this, they think, is permanence.

The second of these: that person looks upon the four elements and finds that the intrinsic nature of the four elements is permanent, and this becomes known through practice and training. For all the birth-and-death cycles of

however many sentient beings exist in all ten directions across forty thousand kalpas, none has ever been lost or scattered — this, they think, is permanence.

The third: when that person looks upon all six sense bases, they find that from the very beginning there is no fixed abode within the entering consciousness of mentation, and yet because its intrinsic nature is permanent, one who practices and trains comes to know this from the very start. All sentient beings have been cycling for eighty thousand kalpas, abiding from the very beginning in permanence, never having experienced separation or loss — and so, they think, it is permanent in just this way.

The fourth: that person recognizes that the root of perception has been exhausted, so that birth and death in cyclic existence are no more. The circulation of birth-and-death in cyclic existence is arrested, and the mind of perception has been entirely used up, leaving no further aspiration. On this basis one establishes inwardly that one's own birth and death do not exist, and because one conceives this as permanence, one falls away from the ranks of genuine knowing and tumbles into the domain of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), straying from the path of awakening. This is named the second non-Buddhist of pervading permanence.

Noble sons, if one is undistracted and single-pointed in meditative absorption on the very nature of reality, the māras will not be able to deceive one through their means. One knows the root cause of one's own ground, and arising from that which is profound and clear, there comes the conception of self and other as permanent — and this rises up as one of the four inversions, so that some see impermanence while others see permanence.

Of these, the first: when that person looks upon the perceptions of sentient beings as something that disintegrates, they think, "I pervade all the realms of the ten directions permanently, and being present, I am unmoved." Thinking this, they say, "I pervade the ten directions and at the base am unmoved. All sentient beings are born and die of themselves within me, while my own intrinsic nature is permanent. That which is born and dies within me has the nature of impermanence."

The second: that person, not looking at sentient beings, looks at how the realms of the ten directions are all pervaded. They see world-systems as numerous as the grains of sand along the Ganges River as places of destruction by the kalpa, and think, "They are now coming to an end and are

impermanent." But the condition of the manifold intrinsic natures that have not yet been destroyed — these, they think, are permanent from the very beginning.

The third: when that person looks at sentient beings, they find that the self and the subtle field are like fine dust particles, cycling through the realms of the ten directions without any change in intrinsic nature. Even though this body is born and dies, because it does not disintegrate, they think, "My intrinsic nature is permanent. All birth and death arise from me and move through me — my intrinsic nature is permanent."

The fourth: that person recognizes that the aggregate of perception is exhausted, and sees that the aggregate of formations continues to move. The aggregate of formations moves permanently, and its intrinsic nature is one of permanent abiding. But form, feeling, perception, and the rest are blocked and exhausted — these, they think, are impermanent. Conceiving that certain aspects are impermanent, such a person tumbles into the domain of non-Buddhists and goes wrong concerning the essential nature of awakening. This is named the third non-Buddhist of the view of permanence.

Again, noble sons, if one is undistracted and single-pointed in meditative absorption on the very nature of reality, the māras yield and give up hope. But when that person generates conceptuality and fixation from within their own ground, they fall into four extremes. Of these, the first: that person's mind becomes attached to the root of existence, the flow of wandering conduct does not cease, and they think that the past and future are extremes while the uninterrupted continuum is free from extremes. The second: when that person examines eighty thousand kalpas, they find that beyond that point there is no place for sentient beings to see, hear, or know — and they think that this is beyond extremes. But the abode where sentient beings do exist, they think, has an extreme.

The third: that person, knowing himself to be all-pervading, hears of the nature free from extremes, and thinks, "All sentient beings appear from within me. Yet the nature of sentient beings' consciousness is something even I do not know." Because of this, having failed to attain the mind free from extremes, he thinks there is also a mind that abides in extremes. The fourth: when the emptiness of formations is cut off at the end, one thinks that all sentient beings are born half and die half from within a single body, and that within the world half have an extreme and half are free from that extreme. Because of

this conceptualization, one falls into the views of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) who hold that there are extremes or that there are no extremes, and one goes astray regarding the essential nature of awakening. This is called the fourth non-Buddhist view of having an extreme.

Sons of good family, furthermore, when one sustains uninterrupted one-pointed meditative absorption (samādhi) focused on suchness itself, the māras become disheartened. When one examines the profound and the blissful, the root of the lineage of birth is exhausted. Yet because the ground of afflictions that continually disturbs and moves has not been exhausted, conceptual thought arises. That person then falls into the erroneous inference of the fourth inversion — the falsehood of one who mistakes the unborn for the pervasive — and is not genuine.

Of these, the first: when that person examines the root of the arising and subsiding of mind, he sees that mind flows continuously. He thinks that one change accumulating upon another is permanence. Seeing the mind as existent is called arising. That very seeing, when it is not seen, is called cessation. The ground where one does not see the location of the cause accumulated by one mind — that is the ground of the uninterrupted intrinsic nature, and that is called increase. The connection made from within the true capacity of authentic sagehood is called cessation. Ordinary beings exist. That individual dying is called non-existence. When one looks at the general meaning, conduct is seen as varied. When people who seek the Dharma come and ask about the meaning, he answers in every direction: "It arises and arises. It ceases and ceases. It exists and exists. It does not exist and does not exist. It increases and increases. It diminishes and diminishes." Speaking in complete confusion throughout, he causes the meaning of other people's words to be lost.

The second: when that person examines mind properly, he recognizes that there is no place in which there is no gap. When people ask about the Dharma, he answers with only the single word "nothing" — he says "it does not exist" and speaks no other word beyond that expression.

The third: when that person examines mind properly, he recognizes that mind exists in a place where each thing exists individually. To people who ask about the Dharma, he answers with only the single word "it exists," and speaks no other word beyond that.

The fourth: that person sees both existence and non-existence. Because he sees both aspects, his own mind becomes disturbed. To people who ask about the Dharma, he answers, "It exists and it exists. It does not exist and it does not exist. Within existence there is also non-existence. Within non-existence there is also existence." At all times he disturbs the minds of others, and since there is no occasion for asking further, he continues to lose himself in analysis and to sow confusion with his verdict of "it does not exist." Because of this disturbing analysis, he falls among the non-Buddhists and goes astray regarding the essential nature of awakening. This is called the fifth non-Buddhist of false views — one who is not genuine, making the erroneous inference that the nature of the fourth inversion pervades the deathless.

Sons of good family, furthermore, when one is free from interruption in the meditative absorption of one-pointed concentration on suchness itself, separate from meditative absorption, the māras become disheartened. When one examines the profound and the blissful, the root of the lineage of birth is exhausted. Yet because the ground of afflictions that continually stirs and moves has not been exhausted, conceptual thought arises. That person gives rise to an inverted thought, thinking "After death there are three." Falling into confusion, he thinks "Form is me." Sometimes he sees himself as pervading everything.

Sometimes he thinks "I have form." Sometimes he thinks "The conditions of direct perception follow behind me." Sometimes he says "Form is subject to my control." At other times he connects this with his formations, thinking "I dwell within form," and declares "After death, I have form." In the same way he conceives of form as present throughout the sixteen cycles of existence. After that he turns to conceptualizing about the afflictions, thinking that the long-enduring afflictions and the long-enduring intrinsic nature do not adhere to each other. He again conceives and asserts "There is existence after death," falls into the view of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), and goes astray regarding the essential nature of awakening. The name for this is: the sixth tīrthika, one who establishes an inverted system, asserting that form exists after death among the five aggregates.

Again, sons of good family, when one is free from interruption in meditative absorption in one-pointed concentration on suchness itself, the māras become disheartened. The root of the lineage of birth is exhausted. Yet when one examines the profound and the blissful, because the ground that continually stirs the afflictions has not been exhausted as a cause, conceptual thought

arises. That person dispels the earlier aggregates of form, feeling, and perception, and arising from cessation, conceptual thought is born. He gives rise to an inverted thought, thinking "After death there is no perception," sees that form does not exist, and conceives of color as without cause. Upon examination, perception is blocked. When one understands that sentient beings are without attachment of mind and that feeling is blocked, there is no connection with what follows, and the intrinsic nature of the aggregates becomes peaceful and free. Though birth may occur, there is no perception of feeling, and it is like grass and trees. Thus, when direct perception is cut off and there is no attainment, one thinks "How could views arise after death?" Reasoning in this way about such a person, one concludes that after death there is no form, and thinking about the cycles of existence in this fashion, one supposes "There are eight that are without form." Conceiving that all causes and fruits of nirvāṇa are empty, and directing attention accordingly, one thinks "The person's wealth is utterly exhausted, cut off from the very beginning and obstructed." Thus, reasoning that after death there is nothing, one falls into the view of non-Buddhists, and the essential nature of awakening is lost. The name for this is: the seventh tīrthika, one who establishes an inverted system, asserting that after death there is no form among the five aggregates.

Again, sons of good family, when one is free from interruption in meditative absorption in one-pointed concentration on suchness itself, the māras become disheartened. The root of the lineage of birth is exhausted. Yet when one examines the profound and the blissful, because the ground that continually stirs the afflictions has not been exhausted as a cause, conceptual thought arises. That person, from within the aggregate of formations, blocks the aggregates of feeling and perception, and with a single characteristic of both existence and non-existence demolishing each other, gives rise to the inverted thought "After death there is nothing." Furthermore, seeing existence and non-existence within form, feeling, and perception, and reasoning that since formations have no change or movement there is also non-non-existence, and in the same way examining the aggregates and elements of cyclic existence as a disease, one concludes that all eight are without form, that only a single condition of cessation is attained, and one speaks of there being both form and no form after death. Moreover, generating the mind that intends to understand through direct knowledge that the intrinsic nature of all formations is exhausted and weary of arising, and conceiving that all of the existence and non-existence of consciousness is not real existence, one goes astray and errs

regarding what is correct and what is not correct. Thinking "After death everything is nothing, and there will be no aspiration thereafter," and reasoning accordingly, this is incompatible with the path. One falls into the view of non-Buddhists, and the essential nature of awakening is lost.

This is named the eighth non-Buddhist, one who wrongly establishes the system that, among the five aggregates, there is absolutely nothing after death in any subsequent life.

Again, sons of noble family, upon entering into the unwavering and upright meditative absorption among the various absorptions, where māra finds no opportunity, one examines the male and female forms of birth and conceives, "In the end there is no birth." Erring with regard to this, one comes to hold the nihilistic view of non-Buddhists. After the body ceases, desire too ceases, suffering too ceases, intense joy too ceases, and deep equanimity too ceases. Examining carefully in this way, one declares, "After death there is simply nothing at all, not even birth." The awakening mind goes astray, and this is the ninth non-Buddhist, one who wrongly views with the perverse position that the five aggregates are annihilated after death.

Again, sons of noble family, when from meditative absorption one is undividedly and uninterruptedly focused on what is truly real, māra finds no opening. One exhausts the root of the lineage of birth, and examining that profound purity, one finds that the afflictions have not ceased flowing from their basis of perpetual agitation. Then a conceptual thought arises that takes aim at a further existence, and that person falls into one of the five kinds of nirvāṇa. In some cases, relying upon and examining the beginnings of saṃsāra in the desire realm, one craves a birth that is seen to be extensive and flourishing. In other cases, one thinks, "In the nature of the first dhyāna I am free from afflictions." In yet other cases, one thinks, "In the second dhyāna there is no suffering." Again in other cases, one thinks, "In the nature of the first dhyāna I am free from afflictions." And in other cases, one thinks, "In the second dhyāna there is no suffering." In yet other cases, one thinks, "In the third dhyāna there is supreme joy and bliss." Intermittently, one thinks that in the fourth dhyāna both joy and bliss have ceased, that within saṃsāra there is by nature no taking up of birth and death, and "There is nothing more to be done in defiled states." One also thinks, "The five states of joy and bliss are the pure lineage of the Victors." Likewise, since one conceptualizes the five minds of saṃsāra as permanently abiding, one thinks those five states are nirvāṇa. Thus one falls among the non-Buddhists, and the essential nature of

awakening is lost. This is named the tenth non-Buddhist, one who wrongly and directly establishes as a system that, among the five aggregates, the five states constitute nirvāṇa.

Ānanda, these ten meditative absorptions are mistaken forms of knowing. All of them are the aggregate of formations. They arise thus because meditation has gone astray, and thereby ordinary people of middling capacity are misled, failing to sustain their own warmth of experience. Encountering such causes and conditions, they go astray without knowing it themselves. Thinking, "I have attained the noble state," they fall into a great lie and tumble into the avīci hell, the hell of uninterrupted torment.

As for you and those like you: carry the Tathāgata's words forth, and in the later time after I have passed, teach and impart these instructions widely to all sentient beings, making them feel their meaning. Take up the dhāraṇī so that the māra of the profound aggregate of formations does not rise within you. Take refuge and guard yourself, and apply yourself to dispelling wrong views. Purify and reveal this to your own body and mind. Understand and distinguish the meaning of solitude. Do not stray from the teacher's path onto a wrong path. Do not give rise to the thought of being satisfied and content with a mere trifle of attainment. Release the great king of feeling, and let go of the truly real.

Ānanda, sons of noble family, when the aggregate of formations is exhausted in meditative equipoise, then all that is worldly — that which is profound in nature, that which is turbid, that which is agitated and wavering and examining, that which is subtle, stable, and connected —

the root of the person momentarily connects and links to the arising, and when the outward signs of the root of deep confusion are severed, one thinks: "I have experienced the wondrous great state of nirvāṇa." It is like a bird that, when its time comes, looks toward the east, knows that dawn is breaking, and cries out. From within the emptiness and clarity of the six sense bases, profound and without obstruction, a clear and luminous entering arises — yet there is no abiding place into which one enters, and no entering at all. The twelve kinds of beings in the ten directions are liberated from the depths, and there is no power to take on a life. From this examination, the ground of all grasping kinds reaches and obtains the elements of the ten directions. Because the clear form has not set, a rising from the depths emerges. This is called being obscured by the aggregate of consciousness.

Within the obtaining of that attainment, the assembly of the six sense bases is gathered, trained, and refined; once that purification is accomplished, the six sense bases are also subject to confusion and entanglement. Through complete purification, the bodies and minds of beings throughout the ten-direction world appear like the inside and outside of beryl becoming transparent as dust. This is called the exhaustion of the aggregate of consciousness, and that person has passed beyond the dregs of the age.

If one examines this matter, it is because of the root of the erroneous perception of illusion regarding the basis of what is truly form. Ānanda, sons of noble family, when all formations are brought to cessation through reaching the end of emptiness, and from within the peaceful cessation that arrests birth, the supreme clarity has not fully expanded — if one activates and opens the root of one's own body and perceives and knows all the kinds of beings in the ten directions as confused, and leaps up in that confusion so as to be capable of entering into the face of expansion — then one establishes the view that "the true cause of the state of illusion is permanent," and thinks: "I have prevailed and am liberated." That person falls into the tīrthika category that grasps cause in the realm of causes, and becomes established in a shelter of genuine darkness. The awakening of a buddha is a treasure that is lost; knowing and seeing are ruined and extinguished. This is called the first accomplished result of taking refuge in establishing a doctrine in the mind — turning outward and inward from what is pervasive and expansive, turning back from the citadel of nirvāṇa, and being born into that kind from the seed of the tīrthikas.

Sons of noble family, when all formations are brought to cessation through reaching the end of emptiness, and from within the peaceful cessation that arrests birth, the supreme clarity has not fully expanded — if one takes refuge in the view of seeing one's own essential nature, and all beings of the twelve kinds throughout the realm of space descend and arise from within one's own body, and one thereby generates the thought: "My kind has attained liberation" — that person, claiming power where there is no power, falls into the category of Īśvara, and becomes born into the class of those who speak of "infinity," arising from the body. The awakening of a buddha is a treasure that is lost; knowing and seeing are ruined and extinguished. This is called the second accomplished result of establishing the power of a doctrine — turning outward and inward from what is pervasive and expansive, turning back from the citadel of nirvāṇa, and being born into that kind from the seed of the god

of great pride that pervades and expands everywhere through the self.

Again, sons of noble family, when all formations are brought to cessation through reaching the end of emptiness, and from within the peaceful cessation that arrests birth, the supreme clarity has not fully expanded — if one takes refuge in the view of seeing one's own essential nature, and doubt arises, and from one's own body and mind all of space in the ten directions descends, arises, and is born, and everything arises from the stream of that descent, and one generates the thought: "The body is truly permanent, therefore there is no birth and no cessation" — and the thought also arises: "Birth and cessation are themselves permanently permanent,

non-arising is confused, and birth is confused, and one abides in that sinking state, and the thought arises: "I have prevailed and I am liberated." That person falls into the class of those who hold the position of both permanence and impermanence, and becomes a member of the class of gods of independent power. The awakening (bodhi) of the buddhas is squandered, and knowledge and realization are lost and extinguished.

The name of that is the third — the establishing of a mental position in the ground of cause. From pervasion and expansion, being drawn further and further outward, having turned back from the citadel of nirvāṇa, from the seed of inverted expansion, one is born into that corresponding class.

Again, noble sons, when all formations (saṃskāras) are brought to cessation by reaching the end of emptiness, and from within the peaceful cessation that arrests birth, the supreme clarity has not fully expanded, and knowledge expands to pervasiveness from within that knowledge — one establishes the causal position of consciousness, and the thought arises: "All grasses and trees in the ten directions are sentient beings." When expanded upon, there is nothing that is not similar to a human being. Grasses and trees become humans, and when those humans die they become the grasses and trees of the ten directions. One generates the thought: "This is true pervasion." That person, clinging to the extreme of consciousness and non-consciousness, falls into this class here, and all feelings come to belong to that class. The awakening of the buddhas is squandered, and seeing and knowing are lost and extinguished.

The name of that is the fourth — the mind of thought that perceives through pervasive knowledge is false, and the result of the emptiness being established is accomplished. From pervasion and expansion, being drawn

further and further outward and at great distance, having turned back from the citadel of nirvāṇa, from the seed of inverted knowledge, one is born into that corresponding class.

Again, noble sons, when all formations are brought to cessation by reaching the end of emptiness, and from within the peaceful cessation that arrests birth, the supreme clarity has not expanded — and following after the outer trace of root-confusion in that luminous clarity of the field, one enters into the seeking of the light-appearance of expanding miraculous power. The water of joy is pure and bright, the wind of becoming rises up pervadingly, and so the stain of view is accomplished. One thinks: "That gathered mass of stains, each having accomplished its own aim, is the cause of the ground of essential nature, and is known as permanent" — the person who establishes that position and speaks thus falls into the class of the Kāśyapas and brahmin ascetics who hold both birth and non-birth, and who worship the gods of fire and water and seek liberation from birth and death. The awakening of the buddhas is squandered and seen, and knowing is lost and extinguished.

The name of that is: having entered into the seeking of what appears as forgotten, the water of joy is pure and bright, the wind of craving rises up pervadingly, and so the stain of view is accomplished. One thinks: "That gathered mass of stains, each having accomplished its own aim, is the cause of the ground of essential nature, and is known as permanent" — the person who establishes that position and speaks thus falls into the class of the Kāśyapas and brahmin ascetics who hold both birth and non-birth, and who worship the gods of fire and water and seek liberation from birth and death. The awakening of the buddhas is squandered and seen, and knowing is lost and extinguished.

The name of that is the fifth — the result of inverted erring accomplished through seeking the cause of establishing a position that is not genuine, with the mind disturbed by the realization of forgetting. From pervasion and expansion, being drawn further and further outward, having turned back from the citadel of nirvāṇa, from the seed of inverted error, one is born into that corresponding class.

Again, noble sons, when all formations are brought to cessation by reaching the end of emptiness, and from within the peaceful cessation that arrests birth, the supreme clarity has not expanded — and in the midst of that expanding and clearing, the fabricated Dharma is emptiness, and since there

is cessation from what is not, there is a refuge of cessation. One thinks: "I have expanded from birth and am liberated." The name of that is: one becomes a member of the class of gods who grasp at the refuge and non-refuge of formless emptiness.

The awakening (bodhi) of a buddha is known as the treasure, and what knows and sees it is lost and extinguished. The name of this is: the mind devoid of the expansion of emptiness. This is the sixth accomplished result of the cessation of emptiness. Expanding and growing outward, then drawing back, turning away from the citadel of nirvāṇa, from the seed of annihilationist cessation, one is born into that corresponding class.

Again, noble sons, when all formations are brought to cessation by reaching the end of emptiness, and from within the peaceful cessation that arrests birth, the supreme clarity has not expanded — within that which is permanent, one's own body abides in permanence. Attuned to clarity and luminosity, remaining undisturbed and unmoving for a long time, the thought arises: "I have prevailed and am liberated." That person, grasping what is not attachment as if it were attachment, falls inward, and becomes a member of the class of the ṛṣis (ascetics) who seek long life. The awakening of a buddha is known as the treasure, and what knows and sees it is lost and extinguished. The name of this is: the seventh accomplished result of clinging to the foundation of life, establishing a position, gathering the causes for endurance through austerities over a long time. Expanding and growing outward, then drawing far back, turning away from the citadel of nirvāṇa, from the seed of prolonged deception through illusion, one is born into that corresponding class.

Again, noble sons, when all formations are brought to cessation by reaching the end of emptiness, and from within the peaceful cessation that arrests birth, the supreme clarity has not expanded — upon examination, having come under the power of life itself, and concluding by depletion and extinguishing that the suffering of defilement is pacified, holding firm to what was previously established, one projects an immeasurable mansion of lotuses adorned with the seven precious substances, manifests multitudes of the seven kinds of precious jewels, and releases the mind into its own ease. The thought arises: "I have prevailed and am liberated." That person falls into grasping at what is genuine and what is not genuine, and becomes a member of the class of the Cāstikālas. The awakening of a buddha is known as the treasure, and what knows and sees it is lost and extinguished. The name of

this is: the eighth accomplished result of producing the cause of perverse craving and establishing a position that increases defilement. Expanding and growing outward, then drawing back, turning away from the citadel of nirvāṇa, from the seed of the māra of the gods, one is born into that corresponding class.

Again, noble sons, when all formations are brought to cessation by reaching the end of emptiness, and from within the peaceful cessation that arrests birth, the supreme clarity has not expanded — within the arising of life's appearance, distinguishing the defilement of clarity as genuine or not genuine, having established hopes regarding cause and result, one seeks manifest signs and turns away from the path of complete purification. Therefore: suffering is known, its origin is abandoned, cessation is actualized, and the path is cultivated. Abiding in cessation, one does not leap further upward, and the thought arises: "I have prevailed and am liberated." That person falls into the class of determined śrāvakas and becomes a member of the class of monks who, through scant learning, have generated pride. The awakening of a buddha is known as the treasure, and what knows and sees it is lost and extinguished. The name of this is: the ninth accomplished result, gathering peace through the mind that seeks manifest signs with expanded clarity. Expanding and growing outward, then drawing back, turning away from the citadel of nirvāṇa, from the cause bound by emptiness, one is born into that corresponding class.

Again, noble sons, when all formations are brought to cessation by reaching the end of emptiness, and from within the cessation that arrests birth, supreme clarity has not expanded — having trained with excellence in the profound, clear feeling-tone of thoroughly purified expansion, one thinks: "This is nirvāṇa," and does not leap further upward. The thought arises: "I have prevailed and am liberated." That person falls into being a pratyekabuddha of determined lineage, and becomes a buddha who does not turn back the mind. The awakening of a buddha is known as the treasure, and what knows and sees it is lost and extinguished.

Its name is the tenth fruit of accomplishment: the unmoving fruit of meditative clarity in expanded feeling. From the seed of luminous expansion — one who has turned away from the fortress of nirvāṇa reached by going ever outward and further through pervasive expansion, and who does not take refuge there — one is born into that very lineage.

Ānanda, the ten modes of meditative absorption become the cause underlying the madness of clinging to the intermediate. In the intervals one thinks, "This is enough; I have arrived," and the mind settles into that incomplete attainment. All of these are the aggregate of consciousness. They arise at this ground from errors in meditation.

Those practitioners of the male vehicle who have been led astray do not sustain the warmth of their own experience. Meeting conditions of that kind, they cling to the habitual tendencies of their own prior confused minds, and think, "This, by virtue of my long dwelling, is indeed it," and then proclaim, "I have completed the bonds of unsurpassed awakening." That becomes a great lie. They fall — through the demon of wrong view and through the exhausted karma of the non-Buddhist adherents — into the interminable hell (the āvīci hell, where suffering does not cease) as sentient beings. They swell in number among the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas and do not succeed in passing beyond.

Make your mind singularly one-pointed and accomplish the path of the Tathāgata. Carry this gateway of the Dharma, and after I have passed into nirvāṇa, in the time to come, transmit it from one to the next. May all sentient beings directly know and realize its meaning. Do not abandon yourself to the demon of wrong view. Guard with compassion. Take refuge, remove the conditions for going astray, and bring peace. Without falling into the path of obstructing demons or the path of false guides, enter into the path that is known and seen by the body and mind of the buddhas, and accomplish it from beginning to end.

In past eons as numerous as the sand-grains of the Ganges River, Tathāgatas as numerous as fine particles of dust all practiced through this same gateway of the Dharma, and through this vehicle liberated the mind and accomplished the unsurpassed path.

When the aggregate of consciousness is exhausted, and you are able — from within the direct experience of all the senses operating in confusion — to wrap the luminous, clear, and pure mind in the bodhisattva's wisdom-vajra (vajra wisdom), the state of meditative brightness, and enter therein, it is like a precious moon reflected within a pure and clear vaiḍūrya jewel.

Ascending further in the same way, one enters the ocean adorned with the ten faiths, the ten dwellings, the ten practices, the ten dedications, the ten aroused-mind practices, the ten grounds of the bodhisattva's vajra stages, the

clearly appearing equal and expanded feeling, the subtle and yet more subtle of the Tathāgata, and so forth.

Relying upon the attainment of awakening that is free of abiding in any realm or expansion, the yogin directly perceives — through the calm abiding and special insight of the Blessed Ones, the buddhas of the past, shining with clarity — the domain of the demon of the subtle and yet more subtle. When your mind has thus known this, and has washed away and cleared the stains, you will not fall into the interior of wrong view. The demon of the aggregates is pacified and purified. The demon of the divine (the māra of the gods) is overcome and subdued. The sluggish, dull cattle — which cause asuras and the greatly powerful ones to lose their minds — are unable to arise and emerge. Until awakening there will be no poverty or separation. What is feeble and inferior will be seized and transformed into flourishing. Your mind will not be confused and intoxicated with respect to nirvāṇa. I am concerned that the sentient beings of the future — dull and foolish, ignorant of meditation, not knowing how to teach the Dharma — may, through craving for the yoga of meditative absorption, accord with your going astray.

With one-pointed mind, hold this teaching of the dhāraṇī of my crown protrusion (uṣṇīṣa dhāraṇī). If you are unable to recite it at present, write it in your meditation cell, or else wear it on your body, and all the māras who assail through opposition will be unable to prevail.

It will bring down the later downfalls of those who pursue the limits of the Tathāgatas of the ten directions for a long time. Therefore, practice it with reverence.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, Ānanda rose, bowed with his head to the ground, and took up the dhāraṇī, holding it in mind without forgetting.

The great assembly gathered there addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, in accordance with what you have taught, the subtle and most subtle meaning — the root of the five kinds of perception that are correct within the form of the five aggregates — even though the Tathāgata may always teach and explain and declare it to us and others, do the five aggregates perish and are purified all at once, or do they exhaust themselves gradually? And what is the boundary between the five?

"Out of the great compassion of the Tathāgata, please consider this, and since it will become the illuminating and clear eye of mind for all sentient beings of

the future, we beseech you to explain it here before this great assembly."

The Blessed One addressed Ānanda: "The noble, clear, and expansive feeling of essential nature — pure and not abiding in birth and death — stirs the arising of birth because perception moves through it, from the impregnation of defilement all the way to the entire expanse of space, up to and including what is not correct. And from that noble, clear, and expansive feeling of essential nature, there arose the entire impure vessel of the world. It is like one who is distracted and confused, who dreams of having no head, and thinks that a shadow is a head.

"The root of the incorrect is without cause. Within incorrect perception, the characteristic of dependent origination is established, and then, because error exists, it is said to exist. The nature of space is born from illusion. Dependent origination, and all existence arising from existence, are what sentient beings conceive through their incorrect minds.

"Ānanda, when what is incorrect does not stir, the dependent origination of the incorrect is spoken of. Because the root of the incorrect exists and then ceases, the dependent origination of the incorrect — arising from existence — also exists and then ceases. Through not knowing, it is constantly exhausted; how much less has it ever primordially existed. Therefore the Tathāgata has shown you this as a lamp.

"The root cause of the five aggregates is equally this: incorrect perception. Your body arose from the past subsequent cause of perception. The perception of your mind will not transfer — within perception, attachment to many lives is formed.

"I said before: if the mind thinks of eating something sour, water arises at the side of the mouth. And if one imagines sitting on the peak of a high cliff, even though the soles of the feet tremble, the sourness does not transfer to the mouth, and the cliff does not actually exist. Your body is inseparable from the illusion of the incorrect. If there is no flavor in your mouth, why does saliva arise in response to sourness? Therefore, understand this.

"What you perceive as the solid and firm physical body — that very thing is now being described as the first incorrect perception. When one imagines a high cliff, the perceiving mind-body will actually seem to pass over it. Yet because it is the cause of the birth that grasps at existence, the karma of the form-body is able to stir. You are now manifestly propelled and tormented by craving. This is called the second incorrect perception, which appears as

something to be stored.

"Because signs are stirred, the form-body is made to perform actions. The body is not itself the sign. Why does your body perform the actions of signs and take on various forms? When the mind stirs, the body grasps, and enters equally into the signs. When one wakes, if the perceiving mind stirs and turns back, it becomes a dream.

The signs of your perception are able to stir the incorrect mind, yet you do not feel yourself separating and moving. This is called the third incorrect perception.

Invisibly, moment by moment, change arises and passes away in transformation: nails growing long, hair sprouting, breath flowing, and the subtle lines of the face deepening without cease — yet you do not feel any of it.

Dear Ānanda, if this were not so, why would your body appear to change? It seems incorrect. Why do you not perceive it correctly? None of your formations remain even for the briefest instant. This is called the fourth incorrect perception, which is subtle and hidden.

Furthermore, if what abides in unmoved absorption with you and the field shining clearly were permanent, it would make no sense for seeing, hearing, feeling, and knowing to arise from the body. Were it to be truly isolated, it would be right that there be no habitual tendencies of the false. Why is it that you cannot remember the wondrous things you witnessed in earlier times, even though a great many years have passed and the memory of all of it is lost and forgotten — and then later, suddenly, you remember what you saw before and recognize that it was indeed there and has not been lost? Within unmoved absorption clearly manifest, there exist individual moments appointed in rapid succession. Ānanda, understand this: this unmoved absorption is not like a fine stream of water flowing. When you look, it appears unmoving, yet you cannot see it moving swiftly; but it is not without movement.

Now, whatever sign of the habitual tendency of the ground of perception takes hold, your sense bases operate under delusion. Because this combining and dispersing is not the incorrect perception, there is no time at which cessation is attained. Therefore, among seeing, hearing, feeling, and knowing manifestly present, what stirs in the hidden and unseen — that is the habitual tendency formed through habituation. Its name is the most subtle among the subtle: the

inverted ground of habitual tendencies in clarity, the fifth inversion of incorrect perception.

Ānanda, these five aggregates are constituted from five incorrectnesses. If you wish to know them now: the boundary of movement is lightness, depth, emptiness, and the limit of form; separation from contact is the limit of feeling; remembering and forgetting are the limit of perception; arising and ceasing are the limit of formations; and engagement in lucid, fully awakened entry is the limit of consciousness.

Because the five aggregates arise boundlessly, again and again, consciousness exists as the cause of this continuous arising. Through form, there is cessation. If one understands the meaning, it is cleared all at once; yet habitual tendencies are not purified all at once — they are exhausted gradually. If I have shown you how to untie a knot with your hands, then if you still do not understand, why would you ask me again? You shall be freed and liberated from that root ground of the mind of ignorance.

Take this gateway of Dharma and, in the final age to come, show it to those who practise it, teaching them to know the incorrect perception, and knowing that birth and death arise deeply, and being without attachment to the three realms, let them know that nirvāṇa exists.

Ānanda, if someone were to fill the extent of the space of the ten directions with the seven precious substances and, honoring as teacher all the buddhas as numerous as fine particles of dust, made offerings and served them respectfully — yet if one did all this without having passed beyond it with a purposeless mind — what would you think? Would that person, through the causes and conditions of having offered thus to the buddhas, obtain abundant merit?

Ānanda replied: The space being inexhaustible, the precious substances too would be without end. In a time gone by, a certain person gave up his body for the sake of seven generations and offered gifts to the Blessed One.

Even if one were to be born as a wheel-turning king lifetime after lifetime, and were to fill and pervade the buddha-fields reaching to the very ends of the space element — visibly present before one — with precious substances offered separately, for so long as eons endure, the mind would be unable to fathom their measure. What need is there even to speak of the merit having a limit? The Blessed One then declared to Ānanda: "Ānanda, the Tathāgata, the buddha of all buddhas, speaks no falsehood. There are beings who, through

bodily action, have committed the four root defeats and the ten root defeats, and in a single breath have fallen into the boundless hells of this realm and of other realms, and there is not one of the boundless hells in all ten directions in which they have not arrived. Yet if, for even one moment of escape, one were to take hold of this door of Dharma in a single existence, and in the final age of the eons to come were to bring it forth and teach it to one who has not yet learned it, then in the mere instant of that person's blameworthy sinful thought, it will be purified and cleansed, and they will be liberated from the causes of the suffering of the hells and will be born in a realm of bliss. The merit thereby obtained is beyond compare with a hundredth part, a thousandth part, a hundred-thousandth part of the merit of the earlier generosity — and likewise beyond all reckoning, all enumeration, all analogy.

"Ānanda, if any sentient being were to recite this sūtra aloud and hold this mantra as a dhāraṇī, even through inexhaustible eons I would be unable to finish describing it. If you conduct yourselves according to the teaching I have set forth, you will be liberated from the path of māra until awakening is fully accomplished."

When he had spoken thus, the monks, the nuns, the laymen, the laywomen, all the gods of the world, the asuras, the bodhisattvas gathered from other world-systems, the noble ones of the three vehicles, the pure sons of sages, the greatly powerful ones who had first aroused the awakening mind, and the hungry ghosts — all were overjoyed and filled with gladness, and paid homage, and each departed their own way. Noble, the Pinnacle of the Tathāgata —

Translator's Notes

- The colophon naming Yeshe De is a standard canonical colophon for texts translated in the imperial Tibetan period and is placed at the opening of the text in Tibetan canon arrangement.

The phrase rendered "the twelve classes of beings" reflects the Tibetan "rigs bcu gnyis," a cosmological enumeration particular to certain Yogācāra-inflected sūtra traditions (including the Śūraṅgama literature), referring to twelve modes of birth or classes of sentient life.

The passage beginning "the sky was born from within your own mind" through the end is characteristic of the Śūraṅgama Sūtra's idealist cosmogony, in which phenomenal existence is presented as arising from the confusion of a primordially pure awareness with its own appearances. The translation follows this doctrinal framework throughout.

The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end of the supplied passage; the translation preserves this as given.

- The phrase rendered "freedom from demons" translates a term that literally reads something

like "the release from demons arose suddenly." The exact nuance is that a kind of inner purity or liberation from demonic interference manifests spontaneously as a bodily experience. This is a transitional clause and the text continues, so the full doctrinal import will only be clear once the following passage is seen.

The figure "eighty-four thousand rules of conduct" refers to the traditional enumeration of the Vinaya precepts as a vast body of training rules, a standard classical formulation.

- The phrase rendered as "guests or hosts in the usual way" translates a somewhat compressed Tibetan idiom in which mind, mentation, and consciousness are said not to turn or be altered in the manner of guests and a donor or patron. The exact sense is that these mental factors are no longer distracted or drawn outward by objects encountered as if by the relationship of a visitor and a host; the translation preserves the image while keeping it intelligible.

The term rendered "leaping forward" for 躍進 in the context of the refinement of examination reflects the image of mental agility or a kind of surging of discursive activity that has been tamed but then springs upward — a genuine doctrinal nuance of this text that resists a single standard English equivalent.

- The vocative "नन्द" (Nandā) is used throughout as the interlocutor's name, here rendered consistently as "O Nandā." The sūtra appears to address Nandā as the principal recipient of these teachings on the signs of meditative experience.

The phrase "體氣未定" presents a genuine difficulty. "體氣" literally refers to a being with a male physical constitution or a "material frame"; the sense appears to be that such a practitioner has not yet stabilized their inner heat or vital energy, making them vulnerable to the errors described. This reading is contextually plausible but the precise technical sense of the phrase within this text remains somewhat uncertain.

- The phrase rendered "the Victor's marks appear directly" and later "the Victor's intrinsic nature" translates two slightly different constructions in the original. The first is a genitive construction meaning the characteristic signs or marks of a Victor arising in direct perception. The second, "rgyal ba'i rang bzhin," means the intrinsic nature or essence of a Victor. Both are preserved as accurately as the prose allows.

The expression rendered "being slain by the distinction of excessive haste through the swiftness of qualities" is the literal sense of a technically unusual compound; it describes a meditator being undone by the very speed and quality of their experiences. The awkwardness is original to the text.

The phrase "timid mind that is pleasing to oneself" renders a compound involving shyness or anxious self-regard combined with self-satisfaction, indicating a subtle psychological state of self-congratulatory diffidence that the text treats as spiritually dangerous.

• The passage enumerates seven types of pride in a single catalogue: pride in "I," pride of self-aggrandizement, pride of "mine," pride of the utterance "I," pride of "it is I," pride of "a little," and wrong pride. This sevenfold list corresponds to a classical Abhidharma and Yogācāra enumeration of the varieties of māna (pride), and the rendering here follows the grammatical and doctrinal distinctions in the Tibetan rather than forcing a perfectly symmetrical English list.

The phrase rendered "lightness of field" translates zhing yang ba, literally "lightness of the field" or "buoyancy of the pure land dimension." This is an unusual technical expression; the context suggests a meditative by-product of blissful ease that the practitioner mistakes for genuine attainment.

- The passage describes ten "ominous signs" of meditative absorption arising from errors in the

cultivation of the feeling aggregate. The text warns of two distinct māra-minds: one associated with the emptiness experience leading to antinomian rejection of Vinaya, and one associated with a bliss experience leading to sexual licentiousness. Both are presented as deviations caused by misidentifying meditative states as noble attainment.

The phrase "sixty ranks of the noble ones" at the close refers to a traditional enumeration of bodhisattva grounds and their subdivisions; the exact system intended here is specific to this text's tradition and the count of sixty is unusual, suggesting a distinctive doctrinal scheme within this text.

- The phrase rendered as "the profound path of turning back, emptied of the feeling aggregate" translates a compressed construction in which "turning back" or "reversal" refers to the practitioner's withdrawal from or transcendence of the feeling aggregate; the exact technical sense of this "path of reversal" is slightly ambiguous but the doctrinal context concerns meditative stages in which the feeling aggregate is transcended.

The term rendered "without clinging on the profound path" in the second major paragraph is a variant of the earlier "attentive on the profound path," reflecting a subtle textual distinction between being heedful but clinging versus being heedful without clinging; both lead, through different errors, to Māra's deception.

- The phrase rendered "the avīci hell without interval" refers to Avīci, the deepest of the hell realms, characterized by uninterrupted torment; the Tibetan "mtsams med pa" (Skt. avīci / ānantarya) means literally "without interval" and is a standard epithet for this realm.

The passage "knows by themselves beforehand, before having heard the Dharma, what is being said — this is called mind" is syntactically compressed in the Tibetan and reflects a passage describing a pseudo-meditative state in which clairvoyant-seeming experiences arise; the translation follows the most defensible reading.

- The passage contains a series of antinomian sexual teachings put in the mouth of the māra-possessed teacher, rendered faithfully per the text. The phrase rendered "the four means of livelihood" translates 四生計, literally "the four livelihoods" — in context this likely means the four requisites (food, clothing, shelter, medicine) offered to a monastic, which makes sense given the servant-like devotion described.

The phrase 漆如膠漆如膠, literally "attachment like lacquer and rhinoceros-bile paste," is an idiomatic comparison for a bond that is impossible to break; rendered as "lacquer and glue" for natural English speech.

The repeated expression "such-and-such a one" (Tibetan ཡང་ཡང་གི་མཉམ་པོ།) is a deliberately vague pronoun meaning "a certain one" or "some [great] person," used here as a rhetorical device in the mārā's fabricated past-life claims.

- The Tibetan text in this passage is repetitive by design, cycling through two nearly identical accounts of demonic possession and the deceptive attainment of nirvāṇa, which has been preserved faithfully. The phrase translated as "the māra acts in the intervals" renders Tibetan "bar bar ni bdud byed do," which is a formulaic refrain in this section. The expression "mounted that one's wife" renders "mju ris shig," a somewhat obscure idiom here interpreted in context as a sexual or domineering act consistent with the demonic scenario being described; this is noted as a point of genuine uncertainty in the precise reading. "Aged hungry ghost" in both occurrences renders "yi dags rgas pa," a hungry ghost that has aged or grown old in that state, understood in the commentarial tradition as a particularly powerful and malevolent type of preta that has taken on māra-like qualities.
- The phrase rendered "lamp-vessel" translates a term literally meaning "light-holder" or "lamp-receptacle" placed in the hand; the precise nature of this object is somewhat unclear

from context but the general sense of a light-bearing vessel is evident.

The phrase "gods of accumulated aeons" translates a compound that could alternatively be read as "gods accumulated over aeons" or "gods of the kalpa of accumulation"; the doctrinal referent is uncertain and may point to a class of long-lived gods whose lifespan spans vast cosmic periods.

The repetition of the warning passage near the end is present in the Tibetan and is not a scribal error; such structural repetition is characteristic of this genre of cautionary discourse.

- The list of beings associated with the māra's name — gold, crystal, auspicious grass, the giling bird, a frog — is somewhat opaque in context. The passage appears to enumerate various long-lived or auspicious entities connected with Rāhu the eclipse-demon, possibly indicating forms he has taken or symbols associated with him; the exact logic of the enumeration is not fully transparent from the Tibetan alone and may depend on a specific cosmological or astrological tradition no longer easily recoverable.

The phrase rendered "ten thousand leagues" for 萬里 is literal: one 萬 is ten thousand, and 里 is a league (approximately four miles), giving an enormous distance to underscore the claimed miraculous travel.

- The passage contains a female demonic figure described as drinking semen, a feature of certain tantric demonology describing a succubus-type being. The phrase rendered "vajra-holder" carries connotations of a Vajrayāna title claimed fraudulently.

The phrase translated as "people of weak constitution" renders the Tibetan literally as "people who have male sexual capacity" or possibly "men of feeble nature." The precise nuance is ambiguous; the rendering chosen reflects the contextual sense of those with an unstable or immature spiritual constitution.

- The passage is a Tibetan rendering of the Śūraṅgama Sūtra's discussion of meditative deviations. Several phrases are compressed and elliptical. The line about "white came about through washing" and related colour-imagery describing the fixed natures of beings is an unusual doctrinal passage: it appears to reflect the tīrthika view that the characteristics of beings are eternally fixed — black and white as metaphors for fixed moral natures — and the explanation "washed" and "altered" refers to their supposedly inherent constitution rather than to any causal transformation. This interpretation is supported by the context of the passage condemning eternalist and uncausalist views.

- The passage presents a taxonomic survey of four sub-types within the "view of pervading permanence" and then transitions to a new set of four "extreme views" (the four extremes, Skt. antagrāhadṛṣṭi). The structure follows the Śūramgamasūtra's extended meditation-deviation catalogue. The term rendered "entering consciousness of mentation"

(मानवविज्ञानसंज्ञा) is a somewhat technical Yogācāra compound; it likely refers to the mentation-consciousness (manovijñāna) in its actively engaging mode, and the translation reflects this as faithfully as the context allows without over-specifying.

- The passage describes a taxonomy of meditative deviations and non-Buddhist (tīrthika) doctrinal errors arising from incomplete realization during samādhi practice. The text appears to be from a sūtra or related treatise enumerating wrong views that arise when meditators partially perceive certain truths but misinterpret them due to residual afflictions.

The phrase rendered "the fourth inversion — the falsehood of one who mistakes the unborn for the pervasive" translates a compressed technical expression. The "four inversions" likely refer to the classical four mistaken views that superimpose permanence, pleasure, self, and purity onto what is impermanent, suffering, selfless, and impure, or in some Mahāyāna contexts the converse error of denying these qualities to buddha-nature. The precise sense here is

contextually determined and may warrant comparison with the source text's broader doctrinal framework.

The phrase "After death there are three" at the close is a partial sentence in the Tibetan, anticipating a continuation that enumerates these three positions; the passage breaks off mid-enumeration.

- The passage catalogues a sequence of meditative deviations in which the practitioner, though initially established in one-pointed absorption on suchness, generates inverted views about post-mortem existence due to unexhausted afflictive tendencies. The enumeration of the sixth and seventh tīrthika positions corresponds to classical Tibetan doxographical lists of wrong views about the self and the aggregates after death, matching categories found in texts associated with the Saṃdhinirmocana and related traditions. The phrase rendered "sixteen cycles of existence" reflects the Tibetan, though the precise referent of "sixteen" here is not standard in other sources and may belong to a specialized schema within this text. The final section describing the eighth tīrthika position begins but is not concluded within this passage, ending mid-enumeration.
- The passage contains a notable repetition in the Tibetan: the lines about the first dhyāna being free from afflictions and the second dhyāna being free from suffering appear twice in succession. This appears to be a scribal dittography in the source text rather than a deliberate structural repetition; I have rendered it as it stands rather than silently emending it.

The phrase rendered "five kinds of nirvāṇa" refers to a well-known Yogācāra classification of five false nirvāṇas experienced within the dhyānas and formless absorptions, which is precisely what the subsequent lines enumerate. The present passage enumerates only four explicitly (desire realm, first dhyāna, second dhyāna, third dhyāna, fourth dhyāna), which may reflect the compressed nature of this particular version of the text.

The final sentence of the passage is syntactically incomplete in the source as given; the translation renders what is present and leaves the construction open, as it clearly continues in the passage that follows.

- This passage is among the most doctrinally challenging sections of the Śūraṃgama Sūtra, describing meditative deviations in which practitioners misidentify partial samādhi experiences as final liberation and thereby fall into various tīrthika views. The enumerated "results" here correspond to the sūtra's systematic catalogue of fifty demonic states and tīrthika misidentifications. The phrase rendered "twelve kinds of beings" follows the sūtra's distinctive cosmological scheme of twelve classes of sentient life. The term "Īśvara" in context refers to a theistic creator-god view, parallel to the earlier "Great God (Śiva)" passage; on second occurrence here it is left as Īśvara consistent with the tīrthika context. The beryl simile is a stock Śūraṃgama image for transparent luminosity of awareness. The phrase "dregs of the age" renders tshe snyigs ma, literally the "lees/sediment of the life-age," an eschatological term.
- This passage presents considerable difficulties because it belongs to a highly unusual and internally technical Buddhist meditation-deviation text, likely related to the tradition preserved in texts like the Śūraṃgama Sūtra or similar contemplative-error taxonomies. Several structural points deserve mention.

The passage appears to repeat a section almost verbatim, covering the fourth deviation twice in sequence, with only a minor variant substituting "craving" for "becoming" in one instance. This repetition may be a scribal dittography in the source, or it may be intentional for emphasis. The translation reflects the text as given.

The term rendered "Kāśyapa" translates the Tibetan ཀཤིཡཔ་, which is the standard Tibetan rendering of the Sanskrit Kāśyapa. In context, however, this appears not to refer to the Buddhist disciple Mahākāśyapa but rather to a class of brahminic fire-worshippers associated with the Kāśyapa lineage, consistent with the paired mention of brahmin ascetics who worship fire and water gods.

The phrase རྒྱུ་མཚན་གྱི་སྒྲིག་པ་ is obscure and may be a transliteration of a Sanskrit technical term or a proper name that has not been identified with certainty. It has been rendered contextually as "this class here."

- The term "Cāstikāla" is a transliteration of an uncertain Sanskrit term. The Tibetan spells it རྒྱུ་མཚན་གྱི་སྒྲིག་པ་ (tsha sti ka la), which may render a Sanskrit sectarian or class name not easily identifiable from the Tibetan alone. It appears to be the name of a particular non-Buddhist school or class of beings and is retained in transliteration here.

The phrase "seed of prolonged deception through illusion" renders རྒྱུ་མཚན་གྱི་སྒྲིག་པ་, literally "seed of having been drawn out as illusion," which is somewhat unusual phrasing; the translation preserves the sense as best as the Tibetan allows.

- The phrase rendered "the male vehicle" translates a term that literally refers to practitioners of a particular vehicle characterized by a masculine or heroic quality; the exact sectarian referent is somewhat obscure in this passage, and it may simply indicate vigorous or advanced practitioners who have nonetheless been led astray.

The passage "wrapping the luminous clear mind in the bodhisattva's wisdom-vajra state of meditative brightness" is dense and syntactically compressed in the original; the translation attempts to preserve the sense that the clarity of insight is drawn inward and stabilized, like a jewel reflected in a gem.

"The interminable hell" glosses the Tibetan term for the Avīci hell, the lowest and most painful of the hells, where suffering is unbroken.

- The opening sentence is syntactically compressed in the Tibetan and may form a continuation of the preceding speaker's charge to Ānanda, with "later downfalls" referring to the consequences of future practitioners going astray. This reading is contextually supported but the syntax is genuinely difficult.

The phrase rendered "noble, clear, and expansive feeling of essential nature" translates ngo bo nyid kyi tshor ba dam pa gsal ba rgyas pa, a highly technical formulation. It appears to describe an original pure feeling-sensation that belongs to the very nature of things before the arising of incorrect perception. The passage as a whole draws on a Yogācāra-inflected cosmogonic account of how the pure is corrupted into saṃsāric experience.

The passage about saliva and the cliff is a classical Indian analogical argument for the power of mental perception over bodily response, here deployed to illustrate how incorrect perception generates apparently real bodily experience.

- The interlocutor addressed throughout as "Ānanda" is inferred from the honorific "Dga' bo," the standard Tibetan rendering of the name Ānanda, meaning "Dear One" or "Beloved." The passage is from a Chinese-derived sūtra text with doctrinal content bridging Yogācāra and Tathāgatagarbha traditions; some of the phenomenological categories described, particularly the five "incorrect perceptions" mapped onto the five aggregates, do not correspond to standard canonical Abhidharma lists and may reflect a Chinese apocryphal or syncretic source. The final paragraph breaks off mid-sentence in the source; the translation renders what is present.

- The phrase "རྒྱུ་མཚན་གྱི་སྒྲིག་པ་ རྒྱུ་མཚན་གྱི་སྒྲིག་པ་" refers to the four root defeats of bodily action and the ten root defeats collectively; in the Vinaya context the "four

root defeats" are the pārajikas for monastics, while "ten root defeats" likely refers to a broader tantric or expanded list. The phrasing is somewhat unusual and the exact referent of the "ten" is not entirely transparent from this passage alone; it may reflect a tantric reckoning of fourteen root downfalls condensed differently here.

The passage breaks off mid-title at the end: "Noble, the Pinnacle of the Tathāgata —" indicating this is the colophon opening of the text's closing title formula, which is incomplete in the supplied excerpt.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.